

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Schools of Vedanta (Vedānta) - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Schools of Vedanta (Vedānta)

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 ultimate reality (brahman)
- 2 appearance through superimposition (adhyāsa)
- 3 indescribable illusion (māyā)
- 4 inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi)
- 5 fivefold difference (pañcavidha-bheda)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Schools of Vedanta (Vedānta) - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - The Vedanta Map: Ultimate reality (brahman), Causation and Advaita Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)

Rapid recall

- Ultimate reality (brahman)'s intrinsic mark: **sat-cit-ananda**; relational mark: **janmadyasya yatah**.
- Advaita: nirguna ultimate; Lord (Īśvara) empirical.
- Visistadvaita: qualified personal ultimate reality (saguṇa-brahman) alone is ultimate.
- Dvaita: Viṣṇu is independent; all else dependent.
- Advaita accepts six means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas), but verbal testimony (śabda) alone reveals Ultimate reality (brahman).
- Trap: nirguna does not mean blank nothingness.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Lord (Īśvara), True self (ātman) and Individual self (jīva): Original, Reflection, Mode or Dependent Self

Rapid recall

- Lord (Īśvara) = Ultimate reality (brahman) conditioned by indescribable illusion (māyā).
- Individual self (jīva) = consciousness conditioned/reflected by ignorance (avidyā) and mind.
- Sakṣi = unaffected witness, never an object.
- Avaccheda: limitation; pratibimba: reflection; abhasa: semblance.
- Ramanuja: real atomic mode; Madhva: real dependent substance.
- Trap: individual self (jīva) and sakṣi are not two ultimately separate consciousnesses in Advaita.

RAPID REVISION 3 - World (jagat) and Causation: Appearance, Divine Body or Real Dependent World

Rapid recall

- Mithya = experienced and sublatale; tuccha = never possible.
- Three Advaita levels: ultimate level (pāramārthika), empirical level (vyāvahārika), illusory level (prātibhāsika).
- Ramanuja: world is real acit and God's body.
- Madhva: world remains real even in liberated knowledge.
- Trap: vivarta is not creation from nothing.

RAPID REVISION 4 - Indescribable illusion (māyā), Ignorance (avidyā) and Superimposition (adhyāsa): How Advaita Explains Bondage

Rapid recall

- Indescribable illusion (māyā): cosmic; ignorance (avidyā): individual, though usage varies.
- Ignorance (avidyā) is beginningless but terminable.
- Superimposition (adhyāsa): *atasmin tad-buddhiḥ*, taking one thing for another.
- Avarana conceals; viksepa projects.
- Hardest Ramanuja objections: locus and means of proof.
- Trap: Advaita does not call indescribable illusion (māyā) absolute non-being.

RAPID REVISION 5 - Liberation (mokṣa) Across Vedānta: Recognition, Communion, Service and Grace

Rapid recall

- Advaita: knowledge directly liberates; liberation while living (jīvanmukti) is possible.
 - Prarabdha sustains the body after knowledge.
 - Ramanuja: communion and service, not identity.
 - Madhva: grace, eternal difference and taratamya.
 - Suddhadvaita: real manifestation and grace.
 - Acintyabhedabheda: inconceivable difference-and-non-difference.
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RAPID REVISION 6 - Ramanuja's Qualified Non-Dualism: Inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) and the Body-Soul Model

Rapid recall

- Inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) = inseparable existence of real modes.
 - Cit and acit are Ultimate reality (brahman)'s prakara.
 - Body-soul relation: supported, controlled, purposive.
 - Ramanuja's Ultimate reality (brahman) has infinite auspicious qualities.
 - Trap: inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) is not numerical identity.
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RAPID REVISION 7 - Madhva and Wider Vedānta: Five Differences, Nimbarka, Vallabha and Caitanya

Rapid recall

- Madhva: five differences, all real and eternal.
 - Do not omit jiva-jiva or matter-matter difference.
 - Nimbarka matter: prakṛta, aprakṛta, kala.
 - Vallabha: world is real manifestation, not maya-illusion.
 - Caitanya: acintya-bhedabheda.
 - Trap: dependence does not mean identity in realist Vedānta.
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RAPID REVISION 8 - Great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) and Error: Tat Tvam Asi, Superimposition (adhyāsa) and Indescribable-error theory (anirvacanīya-khyāti)

Rapid recall

- Tat: Lord (Īśvara) in direct meaning; pure consciousness in implied meaning.
 - Tvam: individual self (jīva) in direct meaning; pure consciousness in implied meaning.
 - Bhaga-tyaga drops contradictory adjuncts.
 - Anirvacanīya: presented but sublated.
 - Superimposition (adhyāsa) is the process; khyati theory explains the erroneous object's status.
 - Trap: great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) identity is not crude empirical sameness.
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RAPID REVISION 9 - Absolutism, Inter-school Debates and the Critique of Vedānta

Rapid recall

- Advaita's strength: maximal metaphysical unity.
- Advaita's cost: lower status of world, agency and personal God.
- Ramanuja's strength: qualified realism and devotion.
- Ramanuja's cost: explaining absolute unity with real modes.
- Madhva's strength: robust realism of relation.
- Madhva's cost: ultimate plurality and hierarchy.

RAPID REVISION 10 - PYQ Routing, Presupposition Ledgers and Answer Architecture

Rapid recall - complete routing spine

Demand	First route
Ultimate reality (brahman)/Lord (Īśvara)	nirguna versus saguna
individual self (jīva)/saksi	avaccheda, reflection and witness
world (jagat)	vivarta versus real manifestation/difference
indescribable illusion (māyā)	seven objections and Advaita replies
liberation (mokṣa)	recognition, communion, service
Ramanuja	inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) and body-soul
Madhva	pancavidhabheda and dependence
great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya)	direct/implied meaning
error	anirvacaniya versus anyatha-khyati

Final memory line: Vedanta asks whether difference is appearance, qualification or ultimate fact.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - 32 QUESTIONS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. MCQs 25-32 are explicit remedial items targeting recurrent Vedanta errors.

MCQ 1

Which formulation correctly distinguishes Ultimate reality (brahman)'s two standard marks?

A. Svarupa: sat-cit-ananda; tatastha: source, sustenance and dissolution of the world B. Svarupa: creatorhood; tatastha: absence of qualities C. Svarupa: five differences; tatastha: body-soul relation D. Svarupa: Indescribable illusion (māyā); tatastha: ignorance (avidyā)

Correct answer: A. Svarupa: sat-cit-ananda; tatastha: source, sustenance and dissolution of the world

Explanation: Svarupa-laksana states intrinsic nature; tatastha-laksana indicates Ultimate reality (brahman) through world-causality.

MCQ 2

Why is verbal testimony (śabda) primary for Ultimate reality (brahman) in Advaita?

A. Because perception is always false B. Because Ultimate reality (brahman) is non-objectifiable and cannot be reached as an ordinary sensory or inferential object C. Because inference is rejected in all empirical matters D. Because only spoken testimony is valid

Correct answer: B. Because Ultimate reality (brahman) is non-objectifiable and cannot be reached as an ordinary sensory or inferential object

Explanation: Advaita accepts perception and inference empirically, but sruti uniquely reveals non-objective Ultimate reality (brahman).

MCQ 3

Ramanuja's main epistemic objection to qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman) is that

A. only inference can know Ultimate reality (brahman) B. qualities belong only to matter C. all cognition is of a qualified object, so a wholly qualifierless Ultimate reality (brahman) cannot be known D. scripture never uses negation

Correct answer: C. all cognition is of a qualified object, so a wholly qualifierless Ultimate reality (brahman) cannot be known

Explanation: Ramanuja reinterprets first cognition but denies cognition of a wholly nirvisesa object.

MCQ 4

In Madhva's metaphysics, the most basic classification is

A. sat and asat B. cit and acit as Ultimate reality (brahman)'s body C. ultimate level (pāramārthika) and empirical level (vyāvahārika) D. Visnu as svatantra and all else as paratantra

Correct answer: D. Visnu as svatantra and all else as paratantra

Explanation: Dvaita grounds its theism in the sole independence of Visnu and dependence of souls and matter.

MCQ 5

In pratibimbavada, defects in the reflecting medium affect

A. the reflected appearance, not original consciousness B. Ultimate reality (brahman) itself C. only Lord (Īśvara), never individual self (jīva) D. the validity of all scripture

Correct answer: A. the reflected appearance, not original consciousness

Explanation: The mirror analogy protects the bimba from the limitations visible in the pratibimba.

MCQ 6

Which statement best distinguishes individual self (jīva) and saksi in Advaita?

A. They are two eternal substances B. Individual self (jīva) is consciousness identified with limiting adjuncts; saksi is the unaffected witness C. Saksi is created by individual self (jīva) D. Individual self (jīva) is real while saksi is illusory

Correct answer: B. Individual self (jīva) is consciousness identified with limiting adjuncts; saksi is the unaffected witness

Explanation: The distinction is standpoint-based, not a duality of ultimate selves.

MCQ 7

Dharma-bhuta-jnana helps Ramanuja explain

A. how Indescribable illusion (māyā) projects the world B. why all selves are identical C. how an atomic self can have cognition extending beyond its atomic size D. why matter is unreal

Correct answer: C. how an atomic self can have cognition extending beyond its atomic size

Explanation: The self is anu, while its attributive consciousness can expand when karmic obstruction is removed.

MCQ 8

Which model emphasises delimitation rather than reflection?

A. Satkhyati B. Abhasavada C. Indescribable-error theory (anirvacanīya-khyāti) D. Avacchedavada

Correct answer: D. Avacchedavada

Explanation: Pot-space is the standard image of apparent limitation in avacchedavada.

MCQ 9

World (jagat) is mithya in Advaita because it is

A. experienced but sublatale, neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being B. never experienced C. identical with tuccha D. an independent material cause

Correct answer: A. experienced but sublatale, neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being

Explanation: Mithya preserves empirical presentation while denying never-sublated reality.

MCQ 10

Apparent transformation (vivartavāda) differs from real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) because vivarta

A. denies causal dependence B. denies real transformation of the cause C. accepts creation from nothing D. makes matter independent of Ultimate reality (brahman)

Correct answer: B. denies real transformation of the cause

Explanation: The effect depends on Ultimate reality (brahman) without Ultimate reality (brahman) changing as milk changes into curd.

MCQ 11

Ramanuja's body-soul analogy primarily establishes that the world is

- A. a dream of the individual self (jīva) B. independent of God C. supported, controlled and purposive as a real mode of God D. identical with God's every attribute

Correct answer: C. supported, controlled and purposive as a real mode of God

Explanation: The three marks of bodyhood ground real dependence without numerical identity.

MCQ 12

Which is NOT one of Advaita's three levels of reality?

- A. Ultimate level (pāramārthika) B. Empirical level (vyāvahārika) C. Illusory level (prātibhāsika) D. Paratantrika

Correct answer: D. Paratantrika

Explanation: Paratantra is a dependence category, especially important in Dvaita, not one of Advaita's three levels.

MCQ 13

Avarana-sakti refers to

- A. concealment of the substrate's true nature B. projection of names and forms C. real transformation of primordial material nature (prakṛti) D. eternal difference among souls

Correct answer: A. concealment of the substrate's true nature

Explanation: Avarana conceals; viksepa projects.

MCQ 14

The asraya-anupapatti asks

- A. whether Ultimate reality (brahman) has qualities B. where ignorance (avidyā) can reside without impurity or circularity C. whether liberation (mokṣa) is blissful D. whether the Veda is authorless

Correct answer: B. where ignorance (avidyā) can reside without impurity or circularity

Explanation: Ultimate reality (brahman) as locus risks impurity; individual self (jīva) as locus risks mutual dependence.

MCQ 15

Superimposition (adhyāsa) is best defined as

- A. absence of all cognition B. real production of the world C. mutual superimposition of self and not-self D. eternal difference between God and soul

Correct answer: C. mutual superimposition of self and not-self

Explanation: Sankara's *atasmin tad-buddhih* captures taking one thing for another.

MCQ 16

The strongest safe formulation of the Maya-avidya relation is

- A. they are always wholly unrelated B. Ramanuja accepts both as anirvacaniya C. Indescribable illusion (māyā) is real and ignorance (avidyā) unreal D. usage varies; often Indescribable illusion (māyā) is cosmic and ignorance (avidyā) individual

Correct answer: D. usage varies; often Indescribable illusion (māyā) is cosmic and ignorance (avidyā) individual

Explanation: Advaita sources vary, so qualified formulation avoids a false universal claim.

MCQ 17

Praptasya praptih means

A. attainment of what is already attained B. production of a new immortal body C. merger of two real substances D. ritual accumulation of merit

Correct answer: A. attainment of what is already attained

Explanation: Advaita liberation removes mistaken non-possession rather than producing Ultimate reality (brahman).

MCQ 18

Already-fructifying action (prārabdha-karma) explains

A. why Ultimate reality (brahman) creates B. why the liberated knower's body may continue after knowledge C. why Indescribable illusion (māyā) is eternal D. why Madhva accepts five differences

Correct answer: B. why the liberated knower's body may continue after knowledge

Explanation: The released-arrow analogy explains continued embodiment without renewed bondage.

MCQ 19

Which school makes taratamya among liberated souls a distinctive doctrine?

A. Advaita B. Visistadvaita C. Dvaita D. Suddhadvaita

Correct answer: C. Dvaita

Explanation: Madhva preserves real jiva-jiva difference and gradation even in liberation (mokṣa).

MCQ 20

Strict Advaitic liberation while living (jīvanmukti) is not central to Ramanuja because

A. he rejects liberation B. he denies consciousness C. he accepts only ritual action D. liberation is perfected real relation, not merely sublation of individuality while embodied

Correct answer: D. liberation is perfected real relation, not merely sublation of individuality while embodied

Explanation: Visistadvaita preserves the real self-God relation and does not treat embodiment as a merely apparent limitation removed by identity-knowledge.

MCQ 21

Inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) means

A. inseparable existence of a real qualifier or mode in relation to its substance B. absolute identity without qualification C. independent plurality D. illusory superimposition

Correct answer: A. inseparable existence of a real qualifier or mode in relation to its substance

Explanation: Ramanuja uses it to hold real cit and acit within one qualified Ultimate reality (brahman).

MCQ 22

Which pair correctly states two of Madhva's five differences?

A. Maya-Brahman and avidya-jiva B. jiva-jiva and jada-jada C. saksi-Isvara and Maya-avidya D. nirguna-saguna and sat-asat

Correct answer: B. jiva-jiva and jada-jada

Explanation: The five include differences among souls and among material things, not only God-world difference.

MCQ 23

Nimbarka's standard threefold classification of acit is

A. sat, cit, ananda B. Indescribable illusion (māyā), ignorance (avidyā), superimposition (adhyāsa) C. prakṛta, aprakṛta and kala D. body, mind and senses

Correct answer: C. prakṛta, aprakṛta and kala

Explanation: This classification places empirical matter, non-prakṛtic divine substance and time within dependent real acit.

MCQ 24

Acintyabhedabheda holds that difference and non-difference are

A. both illusory B. merely linguistic C. successive stages abolished in liberation (mokṣa) D. jointly real but inconceivable in their full relation

Correct answer: D. jointly real but inconceivable in their full relation

Explanation: The Caitanya tradition preserves both poles without reducing one to the other.

MCQ 25

Remedial focus: Which statement corrects the trap 'nirguna means blank nothingness'?

A. Nirguna denies limiting empirical predicates while sat-cit-ananda expresses Ultimate reality (brahman)'s intrinsic nature B. Nirguna means Ultimate reality (brahman) has no reality C. Nirguna is identical with Indescribable illusion (māyā) D. Nirguna is Madhva's name for Visnu

Correct answer: A. Nirguna denies limiting empirical predicates while sat-cit-ananda expresses Ultimate reality (brahman)'s intrinsic nature

Explanation: Advaita's apophatic language removes limitation, not being, consciousness or bliss.

MCQ 26

Remedial focus: Why is inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi) not identity?

A. Because cit and acit are unreal B. Because the real mode is distinct yet cannot exist independently of Ultimate reality (brahman) C. Because Ultimate reality (brahman) is one item among many D. Because relation disappears in devotion

Correct answer: B. Because the real mode is distinct yet cannot exist independently of Ultimate reality (brahman)

Explanation: Inseparability preserves difference within dependence.

MCQ 27

Remedial focus: Which answer correctly handles the 2018 printed claim that Indescribable illusion (māyā) is needed by Ramanuja?

A. Claim Ramanuja accepts Sankara's Indescribable illusion (māyā) unchanged B. Ignore the printed line C. Flag the anomaly and explain that Ramanuja instead needs a real account of plurality through cit, acit and inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi) D. Say both deny the world

Correct answer: C. Flag the anomaly and explain that Ramanuja instead needs a real account of plurality through cit, acit and inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi)

Explanation: The safe answer preserves the paper wording without falsifying Ramanuja's doctrine.

MCQ 28

Remedial focus: Which item is often wrongly omitted from pancavidhabheda?

A. God-soul difference B. soul-matter difference C. God-matter difference D. matter-matter difference

Correct answer: D. matter-matter difference

Explanation: UPSC answers frequently stop at theological difference and omit internal plurality of material things.

MCQ 29

Remedial focus: What does mutual implication by discarding incompatible meanings (bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā) discard in tat tvam asi?

A. Incompatible empirical adjuncts while retaining pure consciousness B. Both words and all meaning C. Only the meaning of tat D. The authority of scripture

Correct answer: A. Incompatible empirical adjuncts while retaining pure consciousness

Explanation: It abandons lordship/finitude conditions, not the common consciousness essence.

MCQ 30

Remedial focus: Why is shell-silver not asat for Advaita?

A. Because it exists eternally B. Because it is presented in experience even though later sublated C. Because Nyaya calls it real D. Because it is Ultimate reality (brahman)

Correct answer: B. Because it is presented in experience even though later sublated

Explanation: Never-present entities such as a hare's horn are *asat*; illusion is phenomenally presented.

MCQ 31

Remedial focus: Which statement best qualifies 'vivarta develops parinama'?

A. They are identical theories B. Vivarta accepts real change more strongly C. Vivarta retains causal dependence but rejects real transformation under the premise of changeless Ultimate reality (brahman) D. Vivarta is Nyaya atomism

Correct answer: C. Vivarta retains causal dependence but rejects real transformation under the premise of changeless Ultimate reality (brahman)

Explanation: The continuity lies in dependence; the rupture lies in denying modification.

MCQ 32

Remedial focus: What is the correct relation between superimposition (*adhyāsa*) and indescribable-error theory (*anirvacanīya-khyāti*)?

A. They are rival Vedanta schools B. Superimposition (*adhyāsa*) is liberation; *khyati* is bondage C. They are exact synonyms with no distinction D. Superimposition (*adhyāsa*) is the superimposing process; *khyati* theory explains the erroneous object's status

Correct answer: D. Superimposition (adhyāsa) is the superimposing process; khyati theory explains the erroneous object's status

Explanation: Connecting but not conflating the two produces a precise Advaita answer.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - The Vedanta Map: Ultimate reality (brahman), Causation and Advaita Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2025 Q6(b), 15 marks:** Ultimate reality (brahman) as both efficient and material cause. Use the spider/web image, then qualify the material-cause claim through vivarta.
- **2023 Q6(a), 20 marks:** Ramanuja's criticism of Sankara's Ultimate reality (brahman) and Lord (Īśvara). Move from epistemology to causation, scripture, devotion and the world.
- **2019 Q8(a), 20 marks:** derive the consequences of absolutism rather than merely defining it.

Marks-wise spine: 10 marks = definition + one contrast + example + verdict; 15 marks = thesis + causal mechanism + rival view + qualification; 20 marks = textual anchor + full argument chain + objections/replies + graded judgement.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Lord (Īśvara), True self (ātman) and Individual self (jīva): Original, Reflection, Mode or Dependent Self

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2020 Q8(c), 15 marks:** distinguish empirical individual self (jīva) from unaffected jīva-saksi; use reflection or limitation without creating two ultimate selves.
- **2022 Q8(a), 20 marks:** place Lord (Īśvara), individual self (jīva) and saksi on Advaita's levels of reality.
- **2025 Q8(a), 20 marks:** define bimba-pratibimba, explain the two media, then show its soteriological significance.

Open with the ontological status, give the named model and analogy, state what it proves, then add the Ramanuja/Madhva objection that a real relation cannot be dissolved merely by redescribing it as appearance.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - World (jagat) and Causation: Appearance, Divine Body or Real Dependent World

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2021 Q8(b), 15 marks:** compare Sankara and Ramanuja on world-status through reality, causation, God-world relation and soteriology.
- **2021 Q8(c), 15 marks:** explain Madhva's individual self (jīva) and world (jagat) as real, dependent and different.
- **2022 Q5(e), 10 marks:** take a qualified stand on vivarta as the logical development of parinama.

Use the rope-snake example only after stating the criterion of **badha** (sublation). A comparison answer should end by identifying the cost each school accepts to protect its account of the absolute.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Indescribable illusion (māyā), Ignorance (avidyā) and Superimposition (adhyāsa): How Advaita Explains Bondage

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2018 Q5(c), 10 marks:** distinguish Ultimate reality (brahman)'s non-objective transcendence from indescribable illusion (māyā)'s neither-real-nor-unreal status.
- **2018 Q7(c), 15 marks:** preserve the printed anomaly; explicitly state that Ramanuja rejects Advaitic indescribable illusion (māyā) and reinterpret the second demand as the problem of explaining plurality.
- **2025 Q5(d), 10 marks:** name all seven objections, explain their common target, and give a short Advaita reply.

For 20-mark critical work, group the objections into locus, nature/proof and removal/cessation; this is more analytical than a bare seven-item list.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Liberation (mokṣa) Across Vedanta: Recognition, Communion, Service and Grace

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2018 Q7(a), 20 marks:** compare Visistadvaita, Dvaita, Suddhadvaita and Acintyabhedabheda by ontology, means, state of the liberated self and role of grace.
- **2022 Q8(c), 15 marks:** Madhva versus Ramanuja; do not collapse both into generic bhakti.
- **2023 Q7(b), 15 marks:** explain "attainment of the attained" with necklace, ignorance-removal and a qualified comment.

Begin with the school's self-God ontology, then derive means and final state. A comparison that starts only with practices misses the philosophical basis of liberation (mokṣa).

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Ramanuja's Qualified Non-Dualism: Inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) and the Body-Soul Model

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2024 Q5(e), 10 marks:** define the body-soul parallel, give its three marks-support, control and purposiveness-and critically qualify the analogy.
- **2023 Q6(a), 20 marks:** use inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) as Ramanuja's positive alternative after criticising qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman) and lower-status Lord (Īśvara).
- **2018 Q7(c), 15 marks:** show why Ramanuja explains plurality through real modes rather than indescribable illusion (māyā).

The highest-scoring answer moves from definition to ontological function, then tests whether the analogy preserves both unity and real difference.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Madhva and Wider Vedanta: Five Differences, Nimbarka, Vallabha and Caitanya

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2020 Q5(d), 10 marks:** list all five differences and explain their epistemic, devotional and soteriological significance.
- **2020 Q5(e), 10 marks:** state Nimbarka's three kinds of matter and connect them to dvaitadvaita.
- **2018 Q7(a), 20 marks:** compare wider Vedanta liberation (mokṣa) without forcing all schools into the Sankara-Ramanuja-Madhva triangle.

Always name the specific school. "Vedanta says" is too broad where the question asks Madhva, Nimbarka, Vallabha or Caitanya.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) and Error: Tat Tvam Asi, Superimposition (adhyāsa) and Indescribable-error theory (anirvacanīya-khyāti)

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2021 Q7(a), 20 marks:** state Nyaya's anyatha-khyati fairly before defending Advaita; end with the third-category objection.
- **2023 Q5(c), 10 marks:** explain vacya/laksya meanings, bhaga-tyaga and the Devadatta illustration.
- **2025 Q7(a) is Samkhya-owned but cross-linked:** use Sankara's pradhana-malla arguments when Vedanta causation is compared with Samkhya.

For an error-theory answer: phenomenon -> rival explanation -> Advaita objections -> positive anirvacaniya account -> metaphysical significance -> qualification.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Absolutism, Inter-school Debates and the Critique of Vedanta

Verified PYQ route and answer structure

- **2019 Q8(a), 20 marks:** derive world, agency, ethics, bhakti, means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) and self-reference consequences.
- **2018 Q5(c), 10 marks:** use the restored distinction between the two kinds of indescribability.
- **2018-2025 trend:** Vedanta rewards comparative conclusions even when one school is named.

Use a two-column criticism/reply structure in the body. The conclusion should be graded: identify what the doctrine explains elegantly, the presupposition on which it depends, and the residual objection.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - PYQ Routing, Presupposition Ledgers and Answer Architecture

Verified corpus and marks-wise architecture

- The continuous local 2018-2025 corpus contains **exactly 20 Vedanta-owned question-parts**.
- 10 marks: 2-3 named anchors, one distinction, one qualification.
- 15 marks: 4-6 anchors, structured comparison or causal chain, objection and verdict.
- 20 marks: 5-8 anchors, complete demand coverage, opponent's prima-facie position (pūrvapakṣa)/reply, comparison table or diagram, graded conclusion.

Every answer should make evidence do work: name *Brahma-sutra-bhasya*, a great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya), rope-snake, body-soul or five differences, then state what the evidence proves and where it remains contested.

Learning Design and Retrieval Map

This practice sequence follows the examiner route: exact verified PYQs -> hard concept MCQs -> targeted remedial items -> original marks-wise Mains practice.

ULTIMATE REALITY (brahman) -> SELF/WORLD RELATION -> BONDAGE -> LIBERATION

causation school comparison indescribable illusion (māyā)/error answer verdict

SOLVED PYQ BANK - ALL 20 VERIFIED VEDANTA QUESTIONS

The wording, year and marks are taken from the continuous local Paper I bank for 2018-2025. There are exactly 20 primary-owned Vedanta question-parts.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: What is the difference between the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Ultimate reality (brahman) and the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Indescribable illusion (māyā) in the Advaita Vedānta system? Discuss.

Model solution

Advaita uses **anirvacaniyata** in two importantly different senses. Ultimate reality (brahman) is indescribable because it is non-dual, non-objectifiable reality; Indescribable illusion (māyā) is indescribable because its ontological status cannot be fixed as either ultimately real or absolutely unreal.

Ultimate reality (brahman). The *Brhadaranyaka Upanisad* method of **neti neti** denies every limiting predicate. This does not make Ultimate reality (brahman) a blank non-being. **Sat-cit-ananda** expresses its intrinsic nature, while ordinary predicates fail because they place an object within a subject-predicate relation. Ultimate reality (brahman)'s indescribability is therefore **transcategorical fullness**: it is the self-luminous ground of every act of description.

Indescribable illusion (māyā). Indescribable illusion (māyā) is experienced through the world and illusion, so it is not **asat** like a hare's horn. Yet Brahman-knowledge sublates it, so it is not **sat**, which Advaita defines as never sublated. Rope-snake and shell-silver show this intermediate, dependent status. Indescribable illusion (māyā)'s indescribability is therefore **ontological indefiniteness under sublation**, not transcendence as ultimate reality.

Ultimate reality (brahman)	Indescribable illusion (māyā)
never sublated	sublated by knowledge
self-established reality	dependent appearance-power
beyond predicates because non-objective	neither sat nor asat
liberating truth	condition of bondage

Thus the same word must not conceal opposite functions: Ultimate reality (brahman) is indescribable because it exceeds finite predication; Indescribable illusion (māyā) because it fails to qualify as ultimate being or sheer non-being.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact distinction, uses *neti neti*, sat-cit-ananda and rope-snake as named evidence, and prevents the common error of placing Ultimate reality (brahman) and Indescribable illusion (māyā) in one ontological class.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Give a comparative exposition of the concept of Liberation (mokṣa) as found in the systems of Viśiṣṭādvaita, Dvaita, Śuddhādvaita and Acintyābheda.

Model solution

The four schools agree that liberation (mokṣa) is release from bondage through a God-centred transformation, but they differ because they assign different final relations among Ultimate reality (brahman), self and world.

Visistadvaita

For **Ramanuja**, the individual self (jīva) is a real atomic mode of Narayana, inseparable through **inseparable dependence (aprthaksiddhi)** but never identical. Bhakti, culminating in **prapatti** and divine grace, removes karmic obstruction. Liberation (mokṣa) is perfected knowledge, bliss and eternal service. The body-soul model proves that dependence can be total without destroying personal identity.

Dvaita

For **Madhva**, Viṣṇu alone is independent and the five differences are eternal. Right knowledge, devotion and grace liberate, but the self never becomes God. **Taratamya** means liberated souls need not possess identical bliss. This preserves devotion most strongly, though it makes hierarchy metaphysically permanent.

Suddhadvaita

For **Vallabha**, Ultimate reality (brahman) as Kṛṣṇa is pure non-dual reality and the world is a real manifestation, not a Maya-produced illusion. The soul is a real expression of Ultimate reality (brahman) whose bliss is obscured.

Grace-oriented devotion, especially the **pusti** path, restores participation in divine bliss without the Advaita claim that the experienced world is mithya.

Acintyabhedabheda

For the Caitanya tradition, individual self (jīva) and world are simultaneously different and non-different from Kṛṣṇa through divine powers; the relation is **acintya**, beyond complete conceptual capture. Loving devotion is both means and end. Liberation is not featureless absorption but fulfilled loving relation.

School	Final self-God relation	Main means	Distinctive result
Visistadvaita	inseparable mode, non-identical	bhakti/prapatti/grace	communion and service
Dvaita	eternal difference	bhakti/right knowledge/grace	service with taratamya
Suddhadvaita	real manifestation/participation	grace and devotion	divine bliss
Acintyabhedabheda	inconceivable difference-non-difference	loving devotion	eternal relational love

The common devotional vocabulary should not hide the metaphysical gradient: qualified unity, strict difference, pure real manifestation and inconceivable dual-nondual relation generate four distinct accounts of freedom.

Why this earns marks: It covers every named school, links ontology to means and final state, uses school-specific terminology, and ends with a comparative rather than generic bhakti conclusion.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: How does Rāmānuja refute the doctrine of Indescribable illusion (māyā) as propounded by Śaṅkara? Why is Indescribable illusion (māyā) needed by both Rāmānuja and Śaṅkara to establish their doctrines? Discuss.

□ **Printed wording:** the philosophically unusual second sentence is printed this way and is retained.

Model solution

The first demand is philosophically clear: Ramanuja refutes Sankara's Indescribable illusion (māyā) through the **sapta-anupapatti**, the seven alleged incoherences of Advaita's ignorance (avidyā) doctrine. The second printed demand is unusual because Ramanuja does **not** require Indescribable illusion (māyā) in Sankara's anirvacaniya sense. It should be answered by distinguishing their rival explanations of plurality.

Ramanuja asks where ignorance (avidyā) resides (**asraya**): in Ultimate reality (brahman) it compromises pure consciousness; in individual self (jīva) it is circular because individual self (jīva) is itself explained through ignorance (avidyā). **Tirodhana** objects that self-luminous Ultimate reality (brahman) cannot be concealed. **Svarupa** and **anirvacaniyatva** object that neither-real-nor-unreal is incoherent. **Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)** asks how positive ignorance (avidyā) is known. **Nivartaka** and **nivrtti** question what knowledge removes ignorance (avidyā) and how an entity of uncertain status can cease.

Advaita replies that ignorance is beginningless, witnessed in "I do not know," inferable from bondage, and sublated by mahavakya-generated knowledge. Cloud-cover explains apparent concealment; rope-snake explains cessation without a new entity being produced. Yet the locus and proof objections retain force because Bhamati and Vivarana give different answers.

Why, then, is Indescribable illusion (māyā) "needed"? **Sankara** needs Indescribable illusion (māyā) as the dependent principle that reconciles changeless Ultimate reality (brahman) with experienced plurality through **vivarta**. **Ramanuja rejects that need**. He explains plurality through real **cit** and **acit**, inseparable from Ultimate reality (brahman) by **inseparable dependence (aprthaksiddhi)**, and through the **sarira-sariri** relation. If the printed line is read charitably, both systems need an account of the one-many relation, but only Sankara calls that explanatory principle Indescribable illusion (māyā).

Thus Ramanuja's critique is constructive, not merely negative: real qualified unity replaces indescribable appearance.

Why this earns marks: It respects the exact printed anomaly, lists and groups the seven objections, presents Advaita replies, and clearly states that Ramanuja does not accept Advaitic Indescribable illusion (māyā).

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain the logical consequences of the metaphysical absolutism of Advaitism.

Model solution

Advaita's metaphysical absolutism holds that **Ultimate reality (brahman) alone is paramarthically real**. The logical consequences follow systematically across world, self, ethics, God and knowledge.

First, the world cannot possess independent ultimate reality. It becomes **mithya**-experienced and causally effective at the empirical level (vyāvahārika) level, yet sublated by Brahman-knowledge. Rope-snake supplies the model: appearance depends on a real substrate without modifying it.

Second, finite individuality and agency become provisional. The individual self (jīva) as doer and enjoyer arises through ignorance (avidyā) and superimposition (adhyāsa); **true self (ātman) is Ultimate reality (brahman)**. This supports liberation by knowledge but generates the objection that bondage of the ever-free self is difficult to explain.

Third, ethics, action and moral consequence (karma) and duty remain binding only within vyavahara. Sankara can preserve moral discipline through **sadhana-catustaya**, but critics argue that ultimate sublation weakens moral realism. The reply is level-sensitive: one cannot invoke ultimate truth to evade empirical obligations while ignorance persists.

Fourth, personal God is relativised. Lord (Īśvara), Ultimate reality (brahman) conditioned by Indescribable illusion (māyā), is omniscient creator and moral governor within cosmic experience, but qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman) alone is final. Ramanuja objects that this makes bhakti and scriptural theism preparatory.

Fifth, all means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)-including sruti-operate through knower-known duality and are finally transcended. Advaita answers the self-reference charge through the ladder or clearing-nut model: scripture removes ignorance and then loses operative relevance.

Finally, liberation (mokṣa) must be recognition, not production: **praptasya praptih**. Liberation while living (jīvanmukti) becomes possible because knowledge, not a future event, destroys bondage.

Advaita therefore gains unmatched unity and an elegant theory of liberation, but at the cost of grading world, agency, devotion and even its own means of proof as lower truth. Its coherence depends on accepting **badha** as the criterion of levels of reality.

Why this earns marks: It derives six consequences from the thesis, connects each to named Advaita doctrines and rival objections, and gives a conditional rather than celebratory verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Point out the significance of the five-fold differences in the Dualistic School of Vedānta.

Model solution

Madhva's **pancavidhabheda** states that five differences are real and eternal: (1) jīva-īśvara, (2) jīva-jīva, (3) jīva-jada, (4) īśvara-jada and (5) jada-jada.

Its first significance is **ontological**. Difference is not produced by ignorance (avidyā) and cannot be sublated by knowledge. This directly rejects Sankara's claim that plurality is only vyavaharically real.

Second, it is **epistemological**. Knowledge requires a real knower, known object and distinction between them. By treating difference as intrinsic, Madhva explains why ordinary and scriptural cognition need not be demoted to a lower

truth.

Third, it is **theological**. Jiva-Isvara difference secures Visnu's independence (**svatantra**) and the soul's complete dependence (**paratantra**). Devotion remains a permanent relation rather than a provisional step toward identity.

Fourth, it is **soteriological**. Liberation (mokṣa) is eternal service, not merger. Jiva-jiva difference also makes **taratamya**, gradation among liberated souls, possible.

Finally, jada-jada and jiva-jada differences give the world robust reality. Matter is neither Ultimate reality (brahman) nor illusion.

The doctrine's strength is clarity about relation and plurality; its cost is a metaphysical pluralism and hierarchy that Advaita regards as incompatible with an absolute. Nevertheless, the five differences form one integrated anti-Advaita system, not a mere list.

Why this earns marks: It names all five differences and explains their ontological, epistemological, theological and soteriological work instead of stopping at enumeration.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the nature and types of matter according to Nimbārka.

Model solution

Nimbarka's **Dvaitadvaita** accepts Ultimate reality (brahman), conscious selves (**cit**) and non-conscious reality (**acit**) as real. Matter is neither illusion nor an independent absolute: it is different from Ultimate reality (brahman) yet non-different through complete dependence.

Standard expositions classify acit into three forms:

1. **Prakṛta**: primordial material nature and its transformations, constituting the empirical cosmos and bodies.
2. **Aprakṛta**: non-prakṛtic substance associated with the divine realm and divine embodiment; it is not produced from ordinary primordial material nature (prakṛti).
3. **Kala**: time, the condition of succession and transformation. Its exact placement varies in summaries, so the adopted classification should be stated rather than embellished.

The philosophical point of the classification is relational. Prakṛta matter changes; aprakṛta reality secures a divine order not reducible to empirical matter; kala explains temporal process. Yet none exists independently of Ultimate reality (brahman). The relation is often understood through power and possessor of power: dependence yields non-difference, while distinct attributes and functions yield difference.

This differs from Sankara, for whom the world is mithya under vivarta, and from Madhva, for whom difference is eternally ultimate. Nimbarka preserves a real world and real selves while refusing complete separation from their ground.

Thus matter in Dvaitadvaita is real, differentiated, transformable and Brahman-dependent. The threefold account supports a metaphysics in which difference and non-difference are equally basic aspects of one relation.

Why this earns marks: It gives the three required types, explains their functions, and connects the classification to Nimbarka's central doctrine rather than presenting isolated labels.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Discuss the nature and relationship of Individual self (jīva) and Jīva-sākṣī according to non-dualism.

Model solution

In Advaita, **individual self (jīva)** and **jīva-sakṣi** are not two ultimately separate selves. They are two standpoints on one consciousness: individual self (jīva) is consciousness appearing as the embodied knower through ignorance (avidyā) and the inner organ; sakṣi is the unaffected witness that illumines those changing states.

The individual self (jīva) says "I know, act, enjoy and suffer." These predicates belong to body, senses and antahkarana through **superimposition (adhyāsa)**. Advaita explains the appearance through **avacchedavada**-one space seeming divided by pots-or **pratibimbavada**-one face reflected differently in mirrors. Both models preserve the original consciousness from real division.

The **saksi** is self-luminous and non-objectifiable. It witnesses waking, dream and deep sleep, as well as pleasure, doubt and memory, without becoming any of them. The continuity recognised across states points to a witness distinct from each mental modification.

Their relation is therefore apparent conditioning, not substance-to-substance connection. Individual self (jīva) is saksi identified with upadhis; saksi is the same consciousness considered free of those identifications. When mahavakya-generated knowledge removes ignorance (avidyā), no individual self (jīva) travels to or merges with another entity. The false limitation is sublated.

A critic may ask how an unreal limitation produces real bondage. Advaita replies that bondage is empirically effective like fear generated by a rope-snake, though cancelled by knowledge. The answer succeeds if levels of reality are accepted; realist schools regard the hidden limiting condition (upādhi) explanation as insufficient.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, gives two internal Advaita models, explains liberation, and avoids the central error of treating individual self (jīva) and saksi as two ultimate consciousnesses.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: How do the advocates of indescribable-error theory (anirvacanīya-khyāti) refute the position of the Naiyāyikas and establish the position of Advaitins regarding the problem of error? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Indescribable-error theory (anirvacanīya-khyāti) explains error by holding that the illusory object is presented but cannot be classified as ultimately real or absolutely unreal. Advaita uses this to reject Nyaya's **anyatha-khyati**.

Nyaya argues that shell-silver illusion presents a real silver known elsewhere in the wrong locus, aided by extraordinary cognition and similarity. The shell is perceived as "this"; remembered real silver supplies "silver"; error is mislocation, not creation of a third ontological object.

Advaita raises three objections. First, the subject experiences silver **here**, not merely a memory of silver elsewhere. Second, correction-"this is shell"-cancels the silver at the locus rather than relocating it. Third, if the presented silver were fully real, it should not be destroyed by knowledge of the substrate.

Advaita's positive account begins with **ignorance (avidyā)**. Defective conditions conceal the shell and project silver. The silver is not **sat**, because it is sublated; not **asat**, because it appears. It is therefore **anirvacaniya**. The criterion is **badha**: never-sublated Ultimate reality (brahman) is ultimate level (pāramārthika), the common world is empirical level (vyāvahārika), and shell-silver is illusory level (prātibhāsika).

The theory has wider metaphysical significance: what illusory silver is to shell, world (jagat) is to Ultimate reality (brahman). Error theory becomes a model for apparent transformation (vivartavāda).

Critically, Nyaya can object that "neither real nor unreal" invents a third category without independent proof. Advaita replies that the categories concern grades of sublatability, not a bare violation of excluded middle. The reply is persuasive within Advaita's level-ontology but not compulsory for a realist who rejects badha as the measure of being.

Why this earns marks: It states Nyaya fairly, gives Advaita's refutation and positive account, links error to metaphysics, and retains the realist objection in the verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Compare and contrast the views of Śaṅkara and Rāmānuja regarding the status of the world.

Model solution

Sankara and Ramanuja agree that the world depends on Ultimate reality (brahman) and is not an autonomous second absolute. They disagree over whether that dependence permits the world to be ultimately real.

For **Sankara**, Ultimate reality (brahman) is changeless nirguna reality. A real transformation would compromise absoluteness; hence creation is **vivarta**, apparent transformation. The world is **mithya**: empirically valid but sublatale, like snake on rope. Lord (Īśvara), individual self (jīvas) and causal order belong to vyavahara, while Ultimate reality (brahman) alone is ultimate level (pāramārthika).

For **Ramanuja**, the world is real **acit**, an inseparable mode of qualified personal ultimate reality (saguṇa-brahman). Through **inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi)** and the **sarira-sariri** model, the universe is God's body: supported, controlled and existing for the indwelling Lord. Creation is a real manifestation through Ultimate reality

(brahman)'s modes, not an illusion.

Dimension	Sankara	Ramanuja
world	mithya	real
causation	vivarta	real manifestation
God-world relation	empirical conditioning	intrinsic body-soul relation
liberation	sublation of world-difference	perfected communion within real relation

Sankara's evidence is the Upanisadic insistence on non-duality and the impossibility of change in the absolute.

Ramanuja cites the same scriptures as describing a qualified, purposive source and argues that negations remove defects, not all qualities.

Sankara protects immutability by lowering world-status; Ramanuja protects world, devotion and scripture by qualifying unity. The stronger view depends on whether absoluteness requires absence of real internal differentiation.

Why this earns marks: It compares the same dimensions, names each causal model and analogy, and ends with the precise presupposition separating the schools.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2021 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain the status of individual self (jīva) and world (jagat) in the philosophy of Madhvācārya.

Model solution

Madhva's Dvaita treats both **individual self (jīva)** and **world (jagat)** as real, dependent and eternally distinct from Visnu. Neither is a product of ignorance, and liberation does not abolish their difference.

The individual self (jīva) is a conscious, finite, dependent substance. Visnu alone is **svatantra**; every soul is **paratantra**. Jiva-Isvara difference is one of the five real differences, while jiva-jiva difference explains genuine plurality among selves. This secures responsibility, devotion and the permanent subject of liberation.

World (jagat) is also real. Matter is distinct from God and soul, and material things differ from one another. The jiva-jada, Isvara-jada and jada-jada differences prevent the world from being reduced either to divine identity or Advaitic appearance. Dependence on God means governance and ontological support, not numerical sameness.

The **pancavidhabheda** system joins the two doctrines: soul-God, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter and matter-matter differences are eternal. Consequently, knowledge reveals difference rather than sublating it. Liberation (mokṣa) is grace-enabled loving service; it preserves selfhood and may include **taratamya** among liberated souls.

Compared with Ramanuja, Madhva rejects even the qualified non-dual claim that selves and world form God's body as inseparable modes. Compared with Sankara, he rejects mithyatva entirely.

The account offers strong realism and religious relation, but its price is ultimate plurality and a contested hierarchy of souls. For Madhva, however, plurality is not an imperfection; it is the ordered reality sustained by Visnu.

Why this earns marks: It explains individual self (jīva) and world (jagat) together through dependence and all five differences, then derives epistemic and soteriological consequences.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Do you agree with the view that 'Apparent transformation (vivartavāda) is the logical development of Real transformation (pariṇāmvāda)'? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Model solution

Apparent transformation (vivartavāda) may be called the logical development of real transformation (pariṇāmvāda) only in a **qualified** sense. It inherits causal dependence but transforms the meaning of effect.

Real transformation (pariṇāmvāda), classically represented by Samkhya, holds that the effect is a real transformation of a pre-existing cause. Milk becomes curd; primordial material nature (prakṛti) evolves into the principles (tattvas). The cause genuinely changes form.

Advaita accepts the pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda) insight that an effect cannot arise from sheer nothing and that the world must depend on a ground. Yet Ultimate reality (brahman) is changeless, partless and

absolute. If Ultimate reality (brahman) really became the world, it would acquire modification and plurality. Hence Sankara converts real transformation into **vivarta**: the effect appears on the cause without altering it, as snake appears on rope.

Vivarta is therefore a "development" because it radicalises the demand that the effect be non-independent of its cause. But it is also a break because it denies the equal reality and real modification affirmed by parinama.

Ramanuja exposes the cost: if the effect is only mithya, scripture, devotion and world-process become lower truth. Sankara replies that empirical validity is preserved until Brahman-knowledge; mithya is not tuccha.

My judgement is conditional. Apparent transformation (vivartavāda) is a logical refinement of causal dependence under the premise of an immutable absolute, but not a straightforward continuation of Samkhya's realist transformation.

Why this earns marks: It defines both theories, uses milk-curd and rope-snake, identifies continuity and rupture, and directly answers "Do you agree?" with a qualified verdict.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2022 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: 'Brahma satyam jaganmithyā, Jīvo Brahmaiva nāparaḥ'. In the light of this statement explain the ontological status of Lord (Īśvara), Individual self (jīva) and Sākṣī as elucidated in Advaita Vedānta.

Model solution

The formula "**Brahma satyam jagan mithya, jivo brahmaiva naparah**" states Advaita's hierarchy: Ultimate reality (brahman) alone is ultimate, the world is dependent appearance, and the individual self (jīva) is not other than Ultimate reality (brahman). Lord (Īśvara), individual self (jīva) and saksi must therefore be located carefully.

Lord (Īśvara) is Ultimate reality (brahman) conditioned by or reflected in **Indescribable illusion (māyā)**. He is omniscient, creator, giver of karmic fruits and the object of devotion. This is not illusory level (prātibhāsika) illusion: Lord (Īśvara) is fully authoritative at the **empirical level (vyāvahārika)** level. Yet creatorhood and omniscience are relational predicates, so qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman) transcends them at the ultimate level (pāramārthika) level.

Individual self (jīva) is the same consciousness conditioned by **ignorance (avidyā)**, body and antahkarana. Avacchedavada compares it to pot-space; pratibimbavada to a face reflected in a limited mirror. Agency, enjoyment and bondage are empirically effective but do not divide Ultimate reality (brahman).

Saksi is pure witness-consciousness, illuminating all mental states without change. It is immediate and non-objectifiable. Unlike individual self (jīva), it is not essentially doer or enjoyer; those predicates arise through superimposition (adhyāsa).

Ultimate reality (brahman)
| Indescribable illusion (māyā) standpoint -> Lord (Īśvara), cosmic knower
| ignorance (avidyā) standpoint -> individual self (jīva), finite knower
| free of identification -> saksi, witness

The distinctions are pedagogical and empirical, not three ultimate substances. Great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) knowledge removes the individual self (jīva)'s limiting identification; Īśvara-jīva difference is also transcended in Ultimate reality (brahman).

Ramanuja objects that this makes God and devotion provisional. Advaita replies that empirical authority is not falsity and remains binding until knowledge. The scheme is coherent if levels of reality are accepted; otherwise it appears to derive theology from an ultimately sublated distinction.

Why this earns marks: It explains all three statuses, uses two Advaita models and the level-ontology, and addresses the theological objection rather than merely repeating the formula.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2022 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: How does the concept of Liberation (Mokṣa) of Madhvācārya differ from that of Rāmānujācārya? Explain.

Model solution

Madhva and Ramanuja both reject Advaitic identity and make devotion and grace central, yet their concepts of liberation (mokṣa) differ because Dvaita affirms eternal difference while Viśiṣṭadvaita affirms inseparable qualified unity.

For **Ramanuja**, the individual self (jīva) is a real atomic mode of Ultimate reality (brahman) through **inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi)**. Bhakti, prapatti and God's grace remove karmic bondage. The liberated self retains individuality and enjoys direct knowledge, bliss and eternal service of Narayana. The body-soul model makes the self wholly dependent but internal to one qualified Ultimate reality (brahman).

For **Madhva**, the individual self (jīva) is a real dependent substance eternally distinct from Visnu and from other individual self (jīvas). Liberation (mokṣa) comes through right knowledge of difference, devotion and grace. It is blissful service, never identity or inclusion as a mode. **Taratamya** means liberated souls may enjoy different degrees of bliss.

Issue	Ramanuja	Madhva
ontology	qualified non-duality	dualism/plural realism
self-God relation	inseparable mode/body	eternal difference
liberating knowledge	dependence within unity	fivefold difference and supremacy of Visnu
final state	communion and service	service with taratamya

Both reject strict Advaita liberation while living (jīvanmukti): liberation is not simply discovering that individuality was unreal. Yet Ramanuja integrates plurality within one divine whole, whereas Madhva refuses all identity.

Thus the difference is not bhakti versus bhakti, but communion within qualified unity versus fulfilment of eternal duality.

Why this earns marks: It establishes common ground, compares ontology, means and final condition, and highlights taratamya and inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) as decisive evidence.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2023 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: What is Advaitin interpretation of the great sentence (mahāvākya) 'Thou art that' (tat tvam asi)? Briefly discuss.

Model solution

Advaita interprets **tat tvam asi** through **mutual implication by discarding incompatible meanings (bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā)** or jahad-ajahal-laksana, because the direct meanings of "that" and "thou" appear contradictory.

The **vacyartha** of *tat* is Lord (Īśvara)-omniscient, cosmic cause and Lord, associated with Indescribable illusion (māyā). The direct meaning of *tvam* is the finite individual self (jīva)-embodied, ignorant and agentive, associated with ignorance (avidyā). These empirical predicates cannot be literally identical.

Advaita therefore abandons the incompatible adjuncts and retains the common **lakṣyartha**, pure consciousness. The classic illustration is **"this is that Devadatta."** Differences of place, time and condition are dropped while the identical person is retained. Similarly, lordship and finitude are dropped; consciousness is recognised as one.

The sentence does not cause a new union. It removes ignorance (avidyā) and reveals an identity always true: true self (ātman) is Ultimate reality (brahman). This is why great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) knowledge can liberate.

Ramanuja and Madhva reject this semantic reduction. They interpret Upanisadic unity through dependence, qualification or relation rather than numerical identity. Thus the reading of one sentence presupposes the entire Advaita ontology.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes direct and implied meanings, explains the precise semantic device, uses the Devadatta example and prevents crude identity between empirical individual self (jīva) and Lord (Īśvara).

Solved PYQ 15 - 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss Rāmānuja's criticism of Śaṅkara's conception of Ultimate reality (brahman) and Lord (Īśvara) (God).

Model solution

Ramanuja criticises Sankara's distinction between qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman) as ultimate and Lord (Īśvara) as Ultimate reality (brahman) conditioned by Indescribable illusion (māyā). His objections are epistemological, scriptural, causal and religious.

First, **all cognition is of the qualified**. Ramanuja accepts a first, nirvikalpaka cognition, but not cognition of a wholly qualifierless object. A nirvisesa Ultimate reality (brahman) therefore cannot become a known referent. Advaita replies that Ultimate reality (brahman) is not an object of perception; sruti reveals it as self-luminous consciousness.

Second, Ramanuja reads scriptural negation as denial of defects, not denial of all qualities. Upanisadic predicates of knowledge, bliss, lordship and causality disclose **ananta-kalyana-gunas**. Sankara's nirguna reading, he argues, turns fullness into abstraction.

Third, an indeterminate Ultimate reality (brahman) cannot intelligibly cause a structured world. If Lord (Īśvara) alone creates but belongs only to vyavahara, ultimate reality is disconnected from cosmology. Ramanuja instead makes Narayana both efficient and material cause through real cit and acit modes.

Fourth, Indescribable illusion (māyā) is incoherent. The **sapta-anupapatti** challenges its locus, concealment, nature, indefinability, proof, remover and cessation. Especially strong are the asraya dilemma and the absence of an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) for positive ignorance (avidyā).

Fifth, reducing Lord (Īśvara) to lower truth weakens bhakti. Scriptural devotion appears merely preparatory to an impersonal realisation. Ramanuja's body-soul model makes God simultaneously immanent, transcendent and ultimately personal.

Advaita responds that qualities introduce relational limitation, whereas nirguna means free from limiting predicates, not blankness. Lord (Īśvara) remains empirically real and indispensable. The debate turns on whether absoluteness is best preserved by excluding real differentiation or by including it as inseparable qualification.

Ramanuja's critique is strongest in exposing the religious and causal costs of lower-status Lord (Īśvara); Advaita remains strongest in protecting immutability and non-duality.

Why this earns marks: It covers all dimensions of the criticism, includes Advaita replies and Ramanuja's positive alternative, and gives a balanced graded conclusion.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Liberation is defined by Advaita Vedāntins as 'attainment of that which is already attained'. How does Śaṅkara illustrate this statement? Discuss with your own comments.

Model solution

Advaita defines liberation (mokṣa) as **praptasya praptih**, attainment of what is already attained, because the self has never truly ceased to be Ultimate reality (brahman). Bondage is ignorance (avidyā), not a real transformation or distance.

Sankara's standard illustration is the **necklace already on one's neck**. A person searches everywhere for a lost necklace until another points out that it is already worn. No new necklace is produced and no journey obtains it; knowledge removes the mistaken non-possession. Similarly, great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) knowledge removes the belief "I am a finite body-mind" and reveals atman-Brahman identity.

The rope-snake makes the negative side clear. Correct knowledge does not destroy a real snake; it sublates a projected one. Liberation (mokṣa) therefore cannot be a karmic effect, because every produced effect is temporary.

Knowledge (jñāna) alone directly liberates; action and moral consequence (karma) and upasana prepare the mind through sadhana-catustaya.

Liberation while living (jīvanmukti) follows logically. Knowledge can dawn while the body continues through **already-fructifying action (prārabdha-karma)**, like an arrow already released. Liberation after bodily death (videhamukti) adds no new essential freedom.

My comment is that the doctrine offers a powerful account of freedom as de-identification rather than acquisition. It avoids making the eternal dependent on a temporal event. Yet it inherits the problem of explaining how beginningless bondage can appear in self-luminous Ultimate reality (brahman). Saying "ignorance (avidyā)" is adequate only if superimposition (adhyāsa) and levels of reality are independently defensible.

Thus liberation is attainment only from the ignorant standpoint; from the highest standpoint it is recognition that non-attainment never occurred.

Why this earns marks: It explains the paradox with necklace, rope-snake and arrow examples, derives knowledge (jñāna) and liberation while living (jīvanmukti), and adds a reasoned critical comment as demanded.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2024 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: "In Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, the relationship between God and the world is parallel to that between an individual self and its body." Critically discuss.

Model solution

In Viśiṣṭādvaita, the God-world relation parallels the relation between an individual self and its body through **body-soul relation (śarīra-śarīrī-bhāva)**. The analogy expresses dependence and control, not a claim that the physical universe is God's gross body in an ordinary sense.

For Ramanuja, something is a body when it is (1) completely supported by a self, (2) controlled by that self, and (3) exists for that self's purposes. Cit and acit satisfy these marks in relation to Narayana. God is their indwelling ruler; world and selves are real modes or **prakara**.

The analogy establishes immanence: nothing lies outside Ultimate reality (brahman)'s sustaining presence. It also preserves transcendence: the indwelling self exceeds and controls the body. Through **inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi)**, the world is inseparable but not numerically identical.

Its strength is that it preserves a real world, meaningful devotion and Ultimate reality (brahman) as both efficient and material cause without Advaitic mithyatva. Its limitation is the problem of defect: if the world is God's body, do suffering and change qualify God? Ramanuja replies that the controller is not reduced to the body's limitations; dependence does not transfer every defect to the indwelling self.

The parallel is therefore philosophically illuminating but analogical, not complete identity. It secures qualified unity: plurality is real yet internal to one divine whole.

Why this earns marks: It states the three technical marks of bodyhood, connects them to inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) and causation, and critically tests rather than merely repeats the analogy.

Solved PYQ 18 - 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Examine Rāmānuja's seven objections against Māyāvāda of Advaita.

Model solution

Ramanuja's **sapta-anupapatti** presents seven objections to Advaita's Indescribable illusion (māyā)/ignorance (avidyā):

1. **Asraya:** ignorance (avidyā) cannot reside in Ultimate reality (brahman) without tainting it, or in individual self (jīva) without circularity.
2. **Tirodhana:** self-luminous Ultimate reality (brahman) cannot be concealed.
3. **Svarupa:** the nature of ignorance (avidyā) is incoherent.
4. **Anirvacaniyatva:** neither real nor unreal appears to violate exhaustive classification.
5. **Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa):** no valid means establishes positive ignorance (avidyā).
6. **Nivartaka:** it is unclear what cognition can remove ignorance (avidyā).
7. **Nivṛtti:** if ignorance (avidyā) is real it cannot cease; if unreal there is nothing to remove.

Advaita replies that ignorance (avidyā) is beginningless but sublatale; concealment is relative to the individual self (jīva) like cloud-cover to a viewer; "I do not know," postulation (arthāpatti) and sruti establish ignorance; and mahavakya-generated knowledge cancels it as rope-knowledge cancels the snake.

The objections target one system at three levels: the **locus**, the **nature/proof**, and the **removal** of ignorance (avidyā). Ramanuja's constructive alternative is real cit and acit inseparable from Ultimate reality (brahman) through inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi).

The asraya and means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) objections remain strongest because Advaita sub-schools differ over the locus and because witness-awareness may be read as mere absence of knowledge.

Why this earns marks: It names all seven, groups their philosophical purpose, gives concise Advaita replies and identifies the strongest residual difficulties.

Solved PYQ 19 - 2025 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: How is Ultimate reality (brahman) conceptualised in Advaita philosophy as both Nimitta and Upādāna Kāraṇa of the World? Discuss with suitable examples.

Model solution

Advaita conceptualises Ultimate reality (brahman) as both **nimitta-karana**, the intelligent efficient cause, and **upadana-karana**, the material basis of the world, because no independent second reality can supply either intelligence or material.

As efficient cause, Ultimate reality (brahman) under the empirical standpoint is Lord (Īśvara)-omniscient, purposive creator and dispenser of karmic fruits. The *Taittiriya* formula that beings arise from, live by and return to the ultimate, and the *Brahma-sutra* opening inquiry into the source of world-order support this role.

As material cause, Ultimate reality (brahman) must underlie every name and form. The **spider and web** image is decisive: the web issues from the spider rather than from alien material. Clay-pot and gold-ornament analogies show the effect's dependence on a common substrate.

Yet Advaita qualifies material causation through **apparent transformation (vivartavāda)**. Ultimate reality (brahman) does not really transform as milk becomes curd. The world appears on Ultimate reality (brahman) as snake on rope. Therefore Ultimate reality (brahman) is the basis of the effect without undergoing modification; Indescribable illusion (māyā) supplies name-form at the empirical level (vyāvahārika) level.

This differs from Samkhya, where unconscious primordial material nature (prakṛti) is material cause and no creator is required, and from Nyaya, where God is efficient cause while eternal atoms are material causes. Advaita reunites both causal functions in one ground.

Ramanuja accepts Ultimate reality (brahman) as both causes but rejects vivarta: cit and acit are real modes and creation is real manifestation. His objection is that apparent material causation risks making the world and divine purpose lower truth. Advaita replies that empirical causality remains valid while the absolute stays changeless.

Thus Ultimate reality (brahman) is both causes, but not in the ordinary transformative sense: intelligent Lord (Īśvara) orders the cosmos, while immutable Ultimate reality (brahman) is the non-dual substrate of its appearance.

Why this earns marks: It defines both causes, gives three named analogies, distinguishes vivarta from transformation, and compares Samkhya, Nyaya and Ramanuja.

Solved PYQ 20 - 2025 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss the idea of Bimba-pratibimbavāda as presented in Vedānta philosophy along with its soteriological significance.

Model solution

Bimba-pratibimbavada is an Advaita model in which one consciousness appears as original and reflection without undergoing real division. It explains the Īśvara-jīva relation and points toward liberation.

The **bimba** is original consciousness. Reflected in the pure cosmic medium of **Indescribable illusion (māyā)**, it is Lord (Īśvara)-omniscient and the regulator of the empirical world. Reflected in individual **ignorance (avidyā)** or antahkarana, it appears as finite individual self (jīva). As one face seems many in differently conditioned mirrors, consciousness appears plural while the original remains unaffected.

The model explains several facts. Dependence is secured because a reflection has no autonomy from its original. Individual variation is explained by differences in reflecting media. Ultimate reality (brahman)'s purity is preserved because a dirty mirror distorts the image, not the face.

It differs from **avacchedavada**, which emphasises limitation like pot-space, and **abhasavada**, which stresses semblance. All agree that individuality is not an ultimate fragmentation of Ultimate reality (brahman).

Its soteriological significance is central. Bondage belongs to identification with the reflected, limited standpoint. When ignorance (avidyā) is removed by great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) knowledge, the individual self (jīva) recognises that its consciousness was never independent of the original. The reflection does not travel, merge or become newly real; false autonomy is sublated. This supports **praptasya praptih** and liberation while living (jīvanmukti).

Ramanuja and Madhva object that the reflection model turns real personhood and devotion into provisional appearance. A further problem is whether unconscious ignorance (avidyā) can literally reflect consciousness. Advaita treats the analogy as explanatory rather than physical: it expresses appearance, dependence and non-affection.

The model is therefore strongest as a soteriological grammar of de-identification, not as a literal optical theory. It connects one consciousness, empirical plurality and liberation without positing real division.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms and media, compares internal Advaita models, derives four explanatory functions and gives a critical soteriological verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

The models follow directive fidelity and the pattern **claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification**.

Original 10-mark Question 1

Question: Distinguish the epistemic role of sruti in Advaita from its role in Visistadvaita. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Advaita and Visistadvaita both treat sruti as authoritative, but the metaphysics it reveals and its relation to other means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) differ.

For Advaita, perception and inference operate within knower-known duality and cannot objectify qualityless ultimate reality (nirguṇa-brahman). Mahavakyas such as **tat tvam asi** reveal the self as non-dual consciousness through mutual implication by discarding incompatible meanings (bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā). Sruti functions like a clearing instrument: it removes ignorance (avidyā) and is itself transcended when the pramana-prameya structure is sublated.

For Ramanuja, sruti reveals a qualified personal Ultimate reality (brahman) with infinite auspicious qualities. His principle that all cognition is of the qualified means scriptural negations remove defects, not every predicate. Texts on creation, indwelling control and devotion disclose real cit and acit as Ultimate reality (brahman)'s body. Sruti therefore confirms, rather than finally dissolves, a real relation among God, self and world.

Thus Advaita gives sruti a unique self-cancelling role in revealing non-objective identity; Visistadvaita gives it an enduring realist-theistic role in revealing qualified unity.

Why this earns marks: It compares function, content and final status of scripture, and uses great Upanishadic statement (mahāvākya) semantics and the body-soul model as evidence.

Original 10-mark Question 2

Question: Why is the distinction between mithya and tuccha indispensable to Advaita? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

The distinction prevents Advaita from collapsing into nihilism. **Tuccha** is sheer impossibility, like a hare's horn: it is never presented. **Mithya** is experienced and causally effective but sublatale, like shell-silver or rope-snake.

World (jagat) must be mithya because ordinary action, ethics, action and moral consequence (karma) and scripture function within it. Calling it tuccha would make error and correction equally impossible. Yet the world cannot be paramarthically real because Brahman-knowledge sublates independent plurality. **Badha** therefore places the world at the empirical level (vyāvahārika) level, between never-sublated Ultimate reality (brahman) and merely illusory illusory level (prātibhāsika) objects.

The distinction also supports apparent transformation (vivartavāda): appearance depends on a real substrate without changing it. Ramanuja objects that this middle status is verbally unstable; Advaita replies that the classification concerns grades of sublatability, not a third bare value between being and non-being.

Hence mithya preserves empirical validity while denying ultimacy; tuccha would erase experience altogether.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, uses two canonical examples, links the distinction to levels of reality and states the realist objection.

Original 15-mark Question 1

Question: Critically examine whether Ramanuja's inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi) successfully mediates between Advaita identity and Dvaita difference. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi) is Ramanuja's doctrine that cit and acit are real, distinct modes that cannot exist independently of Ultimate reality (brahman). It aims to preserve non-duality without treating plurality as illusion.

Against Advaita, it protects real selfhood, world, causation and devotion. The **sarira-sariri** model supplies evidence: a body is supported, controlled and purposive in relation to its indwelling self. Similarly, the universe is internal to Narayana without being numerically identical. This makes scriptural descriptions and bhakti ultimately meaningful.

Against Dvaita, inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi) prevents plurality from becoming a set of substances externally related to God. Nothing exists outside the one qualified whole. Dependence is constitutive rather than merely causal.

Two objections remain. Sankara can argue that real changing modes compromise Ultimate reality (brahman)'s immutability. Madhva can argue that inseparability does not establish non-duality; real difference remains difference. Ramanuja replies that qualifications express divine plenitude, not limitation, and that the controller is not reduced to every defect of the controlled body.

Inseparable dependence (apr̥thaksiddhi) therefore mediates successfully if an absolute may possess real internal differentiation. It does not refute rival first principles, but it offers a coherent third model: neither identity without plurality nor plurality outside unity.

Why this earns marks: It tests the doctrine against both neighbouring schools, uses the three marks of bodyhood, and gives a conditional verdict tied to the central presupposition.

Original 15-mark Question 2

Question: Compare the soteriological implications of pratibimbavada and pancavidhabheda. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Pratibimbavada and pancavidhabheda explain liberation in opposite ways because one treats individuality as reflected appearance while the other treats difference as eternal reality.

In Advaita reflection theory, Brahman-consciousness is the **bimba**; individual self (jīva) is its reflection in ignorance (avidyā), while Lord (Īśvara) is reflection in Indescribable illusion (māyā). Like a face unaffected by a distorted mirror, original consciousness remains pure. Liberation (mokṣa) occurs when knowledge removes identification with the limited reflection. It is **praptasya praptih**, not travel or merger, and supports liberation while living (jīvanmukti).

Madhva's five differences-God-soul, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter and matter-matter-cannot be sublated. Correct knowledge reveals dependence on Visnu and the falsity of identity claims. Liberation (mokṣa) is grace-enabled eternal service, with real selfhood and possible **taratamya** among liberated souls.

Pratibimbavada explains freedom as de-identification and secures metaphysical unity, but critics say it makes personhood and devotion provisional. Pancavidhabheda secures permanent relationship and realism, but accepts ultimate plurality and hierarchy.

Thus their soteriological contrast is recognition of original identity versus fulfilment of eternal difference. Each transforms its ontology directly into a theory of liberation.

Why this earns marks: It covers mechanism, means, final state and criticism for both doctrines, using bimba, praptasya praptih, five differences and taratamya as named evidence.

Original 20-mark Question 1

Question: Does Advaita solve the one-many problem, or merely relocate it into Indescribable illusion (māyā)? Discuss with reference to Ramanuja and Madhva. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Advaita solves the one-many problem by distinguishing levels of reality: changeless Ultimate reality (brahman) alone is ultimate, while plurality arises through Indescribable illusion (māyā) as vivarta. Whether this is a solution or relocation depends on the coherence of Indescribable illusion (māyā).

The positive achievement is substantial. Rope-snake shows how a many-formed appearance can depend on a substrate without modifying it. **Superimposition (adhyāsa)** explains empirical identity by mutual superimposition, while avaccheda and reflection models explain many individual self (jīvas) without partitioning consciousness. The three levels of reality preserve ordinary causality and ethics without granting them ultimacy.

Ramanuja argues that the explanatory burden reappears in Indescribable illusion (māyā). The **sapta-anupapatti** asks for its locus, power of concealment, nature, proof, remover and cessation. The asraya dilemma is acute: Ultimate reality (brahman) as locus risks impurity; individual self (jīva) as locus presupposes what ignorance (avidyā) must explain. Ramanuja replaces Indescribable illusion (māyā) with real cit and acit internally related to Ultimate reality (brahman) through inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi). His model explains plurality directly but must show that changing modes do not compromise the absolute.

Madhva's criticism is more radical. **Pancavidhabheda** makes difference irreducible and argues that cognition, devotion and moral agency presuppose a real knower-known distinction. This avoids Indescribable illusion (māyā)'s third ontological grade but turns ultimate reality into an ordered plurality under Visnu.

Advaita replies that neither qualified nor dualist realism protects Ultimate reality (brahman)'s immutability and non-duality. Indescribable illusion (māyā) is not a second substance; it names experienced but sublatale appearance. The reply works if badha legitimately grades reality. If that criterion is rejected, "anirvacaniya" can look like a label for the unsolved relation.

My verdict is graded. Advaita gives the most economical account of unity and the most powerful soteriology of de-identification. It does not simply ignore plurality. Yet its solution is conditional on a contested level-ontology and leaves the locus of ignorance (avidyā) under pressure. Ramanuja and Madhva remove that pressure only by accepting real differentiation at different strengths.

Why this earns marks: It states Advaita's constructive mechanism, tests the seven-objection and five-difference alternatives, gives replies and judges the precise condition under which the solution succeeds.

Original 20-mark Question 2

Question: Evaluate the claim that every Vedanta theory of liberation (mokṣa) is a compressed expression of its metaphysics. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The claim is largely correct: each Vedanta school carries its account of Ultimate reality (brahman), self and world into the means and final state of liberation.

In Advaita, true self (ātman) is Ultimate reality (brahman) and bondage is superimposition (adhyāsa). Therefore liberation (mokṣa) cannot be a produced event; it is **praptasya praptih** through mahavakya-knowledge. The necklace and rope-snake examples show recognition and sublation, while prarabdha explains liberation while living (jīvanmukti). This is non-dual metaphysics in soteriological form.

In Viśiṣṭadvaita, the self is a real atomic mode of Narayana through inseparable dependence (apṛthaksiddhi). Liberation preserves individuality, so bhakti and prapatti culminate in communion and service. The body-soul model makes dependence perfected rather than abolished.

In Dvaita, pancavidhabheda is eternal. Right knowledge is knowledge of difference and dependence, while grace leads to eternal service. Taratamya among liberated souls follows from real jiva-jiva difference.

Nimbarka's dvaitadvaita yields communion without erasing simultaneous difference and dependence. Vallabha's Suddhadvaita, which treats the world as real manifestation, makes grace restore participation in Kṛṣṇa's bliss rather than cancel world-appearance. Acintyabhedabheda makes loving relation itself ultimate because difference and non-difference are jointly real.

Practice alone cannot explain these variations: the schools may all use devotion, grace and knowledge, but those terms perform different tasks. Nor is metaphysics sufficient without religious discipline; ethical purification and devotion shape the subject capable of liberation.

Thus liberation (mokṣa) is a compressed metaphysics, but not a merely deductive appendix. It is metaphysics translated into existential method: identity yields recognition, qualification yields communion, and difference yields service.

Why this earns marks: It covers the standard and wider schools, links ontology to means and final state, qualifies the thesis, and ends with a comparative formula.